

Tea Tree Oil



What is it?

Tea tree oil is an oil derived from the plant *Melaleuca alternifolia*. It has a camphor-like odor and slight antimicrobial activity. It is often marketed as a “natural” topical antimicrobial and anti-inflammatory agent. It can be present in cosmetics, topical medications, household products, aromatherapy oils and diffusers. Tea tree oil contains fragrance.

Products with the terms *natural*, *unscented*, *hypoallergenic*, and *fragrance free* are not regulated and thus may contain fragrance. Do not trust these labels. However, know that true *fragrance-free* products do exist.

TEA TREE OIL can also be known as:

- *Melaleuca alternifolia*
- Melaleuca oil
- 1,8-cineole
- Eucalyptol
- Terpinen-4-ol
- p-cymene
- alpha-phellandrene

Some Possible Uses of TEA TREE OIL / Where it might be found:

- Skin products marketed as “natural”
- Aromatherapy
- Soap, body wash
- Baby wash
- Facial cleanser, toner
- Shaving cream, gel
- Shampoo, conditioner
- Lip balm, ointment
- Toothpaste
- Mouthwash

- Dental floss
- Face cream, serum
- Hand or foot cream
- Deodorant
- Perfume, cologne
- Sunscreen
- Acne treatment
- Massage oil, lotion
- Psoriasis or dandruff remedies
- Anti-itch treatment
- Foot scrub, pumice
- Antifungal agents
- Wound care products
- Household cleanser
- Laundry detergent/stain remover
- Fabric softener
- Household disinfectant
- Pet products
- Insect repellants

Other products that might react like TEA TREE OIL:

- Any fragrance
- Propolis
- Colophony

What should I do to avoid TEA TREE OIL?

Avoid all fragrances (synthetic or natural), essential oils, and products that contain botanicals / tea tree oil for its antimicrobial or preservative properties. Avoid aromatherapy diffusers.

Products labeled “fragrance-free” or “unscented” may still contain tea-tree-related fragrances as these terms are unregulated. Avoid botanical

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ingredients (i.e. those that sound like a flower or plant extract) as these may cause dermatitis.

You may have to avoid airborne fragrance. For example, candles and incense. Exposure may also occur from contact with partners that use fragrance.

Tea tree oil can be avoided by reading a product's full ingredient list on the original box/package. Some products' ingredient list may be found on the manufacturer's or store's website.

For products already at home that do not contain a list of ingredients, go to the store and inspect the original box or package.

Ask other professionals who use products on your skin (hairdresser, aesthetician, physician, nurse, manicurist, masseuse) to avoid using products containing tea tree oil, other essential oils, or other plant derivatives on your skin.

To identify workplace exposure, check ingredient lists. Sometimes fragrance is present even though not listed. You may need to contact the manufacturer. Material Safety Data Sheets (MSDS) sheets usually do not include the full ingredient list. Substitute fragrance-free alternatives or wear rubber or vinyl gloves.

In addition, the ACDS Contact Allergen Management Program® (CAMP®) can help manage contact dermatitis. It helps to find products that are safe to use by creating a list of products that do not contain one's allergens. For more information about CAMP®, please ask your doctor or visit www.contactderm.org.

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